

Catastrophe (CAT) Claims Surge Protocol

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Audience: Claims operations

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1. When This Protocol Applies

This protocol activates when Meridian Mutual declares a Catastrophe (CAT) event — typically a single weather event (hailstorm, wind event, flood) generating a surge of claims across a shared geographic area within a short window, as distinct from the ordinary, steady rate of individual claims this corpus's other guidance assumes.

2. Modified Acknowledgment Timeline

During a declared CAT event, the standard claim-acknowledgment timeline (Policy Wording Section 8.1 — 10 business days under PAP-2025-STD, 15 under PAP-2024-STD) may be extended by up to 5 additional business days, provided policyholders are notified of the extension and the reason for it. This is the only provision in this corpus that modifies a Policy Wording timeline operationally without amending the policy itself — it is a claims-operations accommodation, not a coverage change.

3. Triage, Not Suspension, of the Standard Sequence

A CAT-declared surge changes the order claims are worked in, not the adjudication sequence itself. Every claim — CAT-related or not — still goes through all five steps in the Claims Adjudication Guidelines: policy version match, coverage evaluation, exclusion detection, deterministic payout computation, and adjuster approval before communication. Triage during a CAT event may prioritize claims by severity (total-loss-likely, uninhabitable dwelling equivalents, or safety hazards) but does not skip steps for any claim.

4. Additional Anomaly Indicator During a CAT Event

A claim reporting damage inconsistent with the declared CAT event's geographic area or date range (Claims Adjudication Guidelines, Section 3, anomaly indicators)

is flagged with additional scrutiny during a CAT surge specifically, since claim volume and urgency during a surge are exactly the conditions under which an inconsistent claim is easiest to miss.

5. Vendor Capacity

CAT events may exceed the capacity of Meridian Mutual's standard repair-estimate vendor network (see Producer Manual Excerpt for the standard network reference). Adjusters may accept an independent estimate from outside the standard network during a declared CAT event, subject to the same documentation requirements as any other estimate.

6. Declaration and Termination

A CAT event is declared and terminated by Claims Operations leadership, with the declaration period explicitly recorded on any claim adjudicated under this protocol's modified timeline, so the exception is auditable rather than silently applied.